

diplomacy

INDO-JAPAN RELATIONS

■ By Saurabh Shukla

For economist-turned-Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, juggling with numbers comes naturally. But when he met his Japanese counterpart Shinzo Abe in Tokyo last year, it was not sushi that he was offered. Abe had some jottings from geometry for Singh.

Abe, in whose strategic calculus India fares quite high, indicated that 'strategic triangle' may be a passé and suggested a 'quadrilateral' relationship among India, the US, Japan and Australia. Singh acknowledged the offer saying that the idea had its merits and since then officials from the four nations have been, for months, quietly discussing the idea that has wider strategic connotations.

The quadrilateral was formally kicked off in Manila on May 25 this year, on the sidelines of an ASEAN regional forum meet. What may follow is a foreign minister-level meeting on the sidelines of the ASEAN regional forum meet in July. This will be followed by a summit-level meet on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly session in New York. "The grouping is not a strategic alliance aimed against someone, but a balancing approach to foreign policy, and we will work on our convergence," said a senior official of the Ministry of External Affairs.

While the relationship is mutually exclusive and does not endanger the strategic triangle of Russia, India and China, the quadrilateral has a geopolitical significance. And if the development follows the script, the growing convergence among the big boys of Asia-Pacific promises to make it a formidable partnership. The four-nation group, broadly based on its earlier coalition against tsunami, are now working to contain the fallout of natural disasters. It is also driven by the buoyant bilateral ties that India enjoys with each of these countries.

But beyond the quadrilateral, what has seen a big turnaround is India's bilateral relations with Japan, powered by the new Japanese prime minister. Abe, whose grandfather Kishi visited India as a prime minister in 1957 to cement ties with the country, thought of it like an unfinished agenda. Since last year, India's relationship with Japan



LOVE WITH TOKYO

Driven by geopolitical interests and the need to balance the rise of China, India and Japan forge a new strategic partnership

has grown at a feverish pace, with almost two dozen high-level visits back and forth besides a scheduled autumn visit of Abe. Prior to that, Indian officials are preparing for a summit between Singh and Abe on the sidelines of the G-8 Summit in Germany in June.

Minister for External Affairs Pranab Mukherjee initiated the strategic dialogue with Japan during his visit to Tokyo in March and his counterpart Taro Aso was in Delhi in April. This was followed by back-to-back visits and a preparatory visit by Japanese Deputy

Foreign Minister Shotaro Yachi to Delhi.

Besides the strategic congruence, and a larger goal to develop an alternative to communist China, India figures prominently in Japan's arc of freedom and prosperity. "Both the countries have complementary strategic interests. They want to maximise the opportunities available to them and want to balance the rise of China," says strategic analyst Commodore C. Uday Bhaskar.

This seems to be the prime driver, and such is the intensity of the relationship that the flights coming from Tokyo